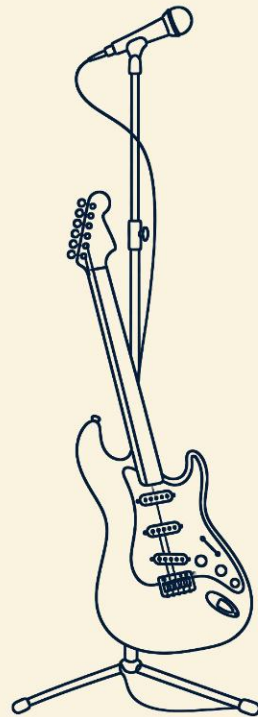


JOHNNY HALLYDAY & FRANÇOISE HARDY

The Yéyé Explosion



22 June 1963, Place de la Nation. A free concert to celebrate a radio show's birthday. The organisers expect twenty thousand.



More than a hundred and fifty thousand teenagers come. Cars are overturned. The press speaks of riots.

The Night Paris Was Afraid of Its Children

A sociologist invents a word for them: yé-yé

Edgar Morin, in Le Monde, two weeks later. France has just discovered it has a youth.

A generation imported American rock — and sent something new back.

Two Children of the Same Paris



Introduction to the Subject and Guiding Thread

Born seven months apart, in the same arrondissement.

Jean-Philippe Smet, June 1943, and Françoise Hardy, January 1944 — both in the 9th, both abandoned by their fathers, both raised by women.

Two opposite answers.

He becomes the rock animal: leather, sweat, the stage as a boxing ring. She becomes the melancholy icon: a guitar, a fringe, a voice barely above a whisper.

One desire.

A baby-boom generation wants a music of its own, in its own language. Both give it to them — and then outlive the fashion that made them.

Two faces of the yéyé years: the shout and the murmur.

PART 1

THE BIRTH OF A YOUTH

Elvis, a Transistor Radio, and a Magazine Called Salut les Copains



The Four Founding Dates

The arc of a generation in four milestones.

1960

Johnny's first record, T'aimer follement. Rock in French.

1962

Tous les garçons et les filles.
Françoise Hardy sells two million.

1963

Place de la Nation. The concert
that alarmed the country.

2017

Johnny's funeral down the
Champs-Élysées, 700 bikers
ahead. Hardy dies in 2024.

From a borrowed American name to a national funeral: the arc of yé-yé.

France at the Turn of the 1960s

A Baby Boom Waiting for a Soundtrack

The baby boom

The largest generation of teenagers France has ever had



The transistor radio

A station in a bedroom,
1959



Elvis

American rock, in
English, on Europe 1



Yé-yé

A youth that needed a sound

The audience was ready before the artists were.

Jean-Philippe Smet Becomes Johnny

An Absent Father, a Troupe of Dancers, and Elvis

A boy raised backstage.

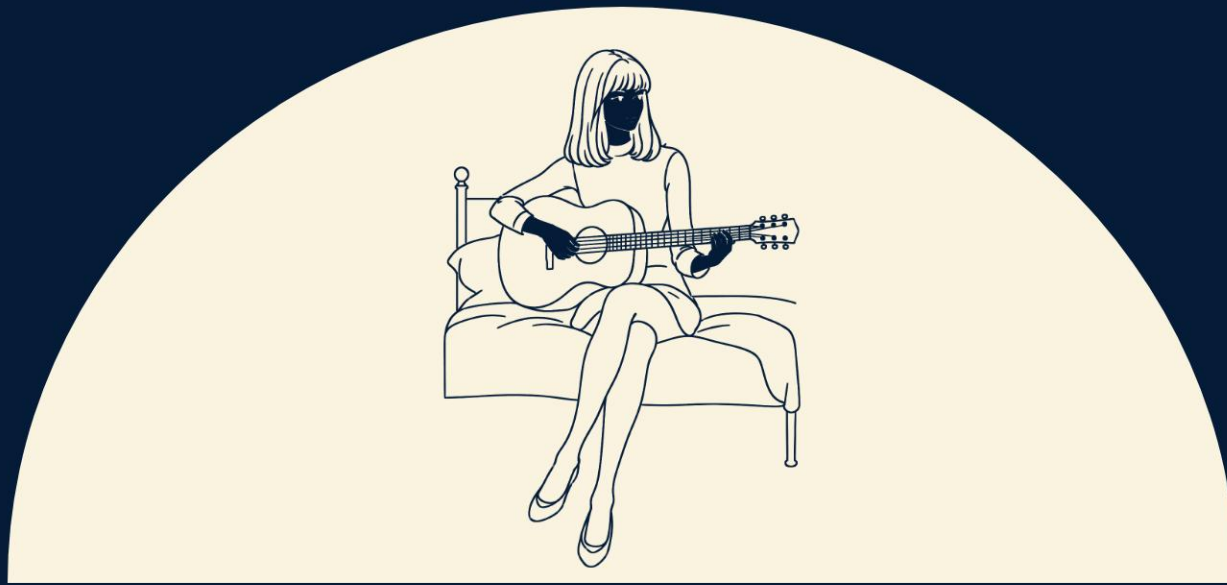
The Belgian father leaves within months. The child is raised by an aunt and two dancer cousins, touring cabarets across Europe; the American dancer Lee Halliday gives him a name.



1957: Loving You.

He sees Elvis Presley in a cinema and decides, at fourteen, what he will be. He learns the moves in front of a mirror.

He did not invent French rock. He was the first to make France believe it existed.



Françoise Hardy — A Girl in Her Room

Rue d'Aumale. A strict mother, an absent and married father, a younger sister, a convent school. A guitar as a reward for passing the baccalauréat.

November 1961. She answers a small ad from Vogue Records and is signed. She writes her own songs — rare for a woman in France, almost unheard of at eighteen.

28 October 1962. Tous les garçons et les filles is broadcast on television between the results of a national referendum. The next morning the whole country knows the song.

Where Johnny shouted, she confided. Both were saying the same thing: nobody loves us yet.



Salut les Copains

A Radio Show, a Magazine, and a Business Model

The show. Daniel Filipacchi and Frank Ténot, Europe 1, every evening at five. The first programme in France made for teenagers and presented as if they mattered.

The magazine, July 1962. A glossy monthly with posters, lyrics and photographs by Jean-Marie Périer. It sells a million copies within a year.

The system. Radio, press, records and photographs owned or steered by the same people. Yé-yé is the first French youth culture — and the first French youth industry.

The generation thought it had found a voice. It had also been found by a market.

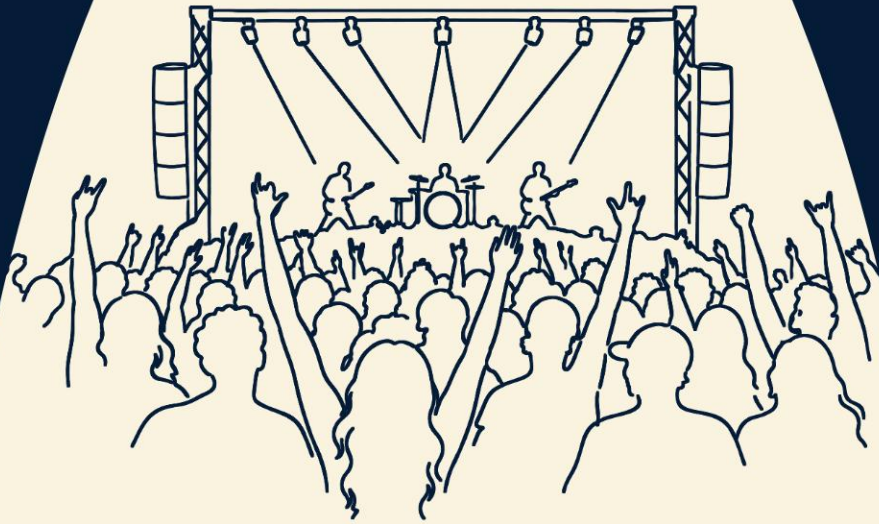
PART 2

THE EXPLOSION

*The Concert, the Photograph, and the Invention
of a French Pop*



22 June 1963: Place de la Nation



The Concert That Alarmed the Country

The plan.

A free open-air concert for the first anniversary of the magazine. Johnny, Sylvie Vartan, Richard Anthony, Les Chats Sauvages.

The night.

Estimates run from a hundred and fifty to two hundred thousand. Trees climbed, cars crushed, dozens of arrests.

The word.

Edgar Morin, in Le Monde on 6 and 7 July, analyses the crowd and names the phenomenon after its refrain: yé-yé. A sociologist gives a generation its label.

France discovered, in one evening, that it had a youth — and that the youth had a music.

The Photograph of a Generation

6–7 July 1963

Edgar Morin, in Le Monde, names the phenomenon after its refrain.

YÉ-YÉ

April 1966

Jean-Marie Périé gathers forty-six faces in one courtyard for Salut les copains.

Seven years

That is how long yé-yé lasted. The photograph made it look eternal.

Yé-yé lasted about seven years. The photograph made it look eternal.

The Rock Animal

Johnny on Stage, 1961–2016

The body.

He does not sing a concert; he survives it. Knees on the floor, shirt torn, a voice that grows larger with each decade.

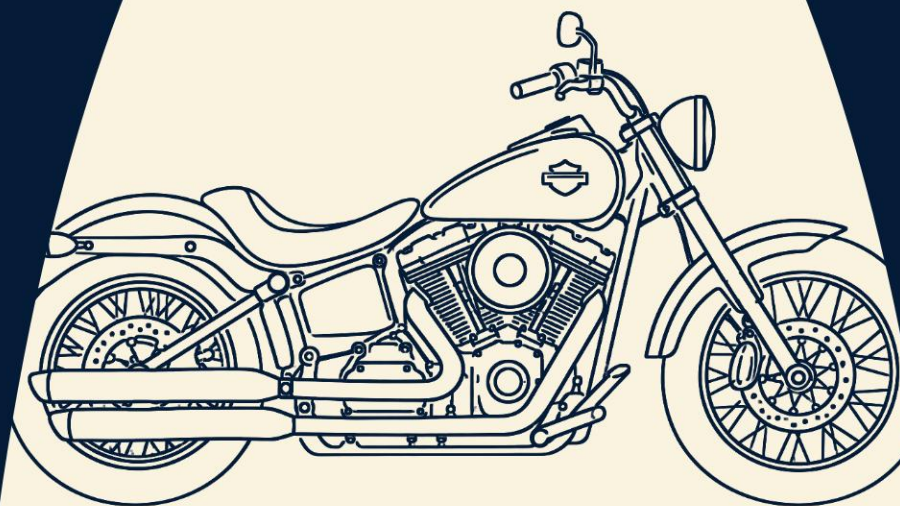
The scale.

Parc des Princes 1993, Stade de France 1998 — three nights, 240,000 people — the Eiffel Tower in 2000. The biggest live act in the history of the French language.

The paradox.

He sings American music, rides Harley-Davidsons, lives in Los Angeles — and never breaks through in the United States. His America is a French dream of America.

“The idol of the young” grew old with his public and never once lowered his voice.





The Melancholy Icon

Françoise Hardy — Fashion, Dylan, and Stage Fright

The look. Courrèges, Paco Rabanne, Yves Saint Laurent dress her. Mick Jagger calls her his ideal woman; Bob Dylan writes her a poem on the sleeve of a 1964 album. **The retreat.** Stage fright is unbearable. In 1968 she stops touring for good and becomes a studio artist — an almost unthinkable choice at the height of fame. **The songs.** Comment te dire adieu (1968, lyrics by Gainsbourg), Message personnel (1973, Michel Berger), La question (1971). A whisper that aged better than most shouts.

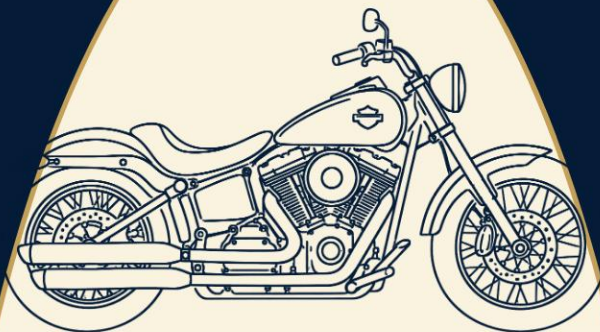
She exported a French idea of cool without ever raising her voice — or leaving her room.

PART 3

THE LEGACY

*What a Generation Imported — and What It
Sent Back*





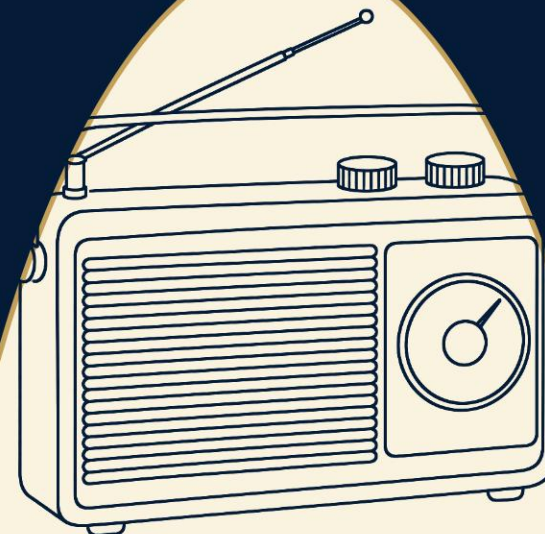
Johnny — The Public Monument

Films with Godard (Détective), Leconte (L'Homme du train), Johnnie To (Vengeance). Lung cancer, 5 December 2017. A “popular homage” on the Champs-Élysées led by the President.



Françoise — The Private Legend

Partner of Jacques Dutronc, mother of Thomas. Astrology, novels, a lymphoma fought for twenty years. Dies 11 June 2024, aged eighty, having argued publicly for the right to die with dignity.



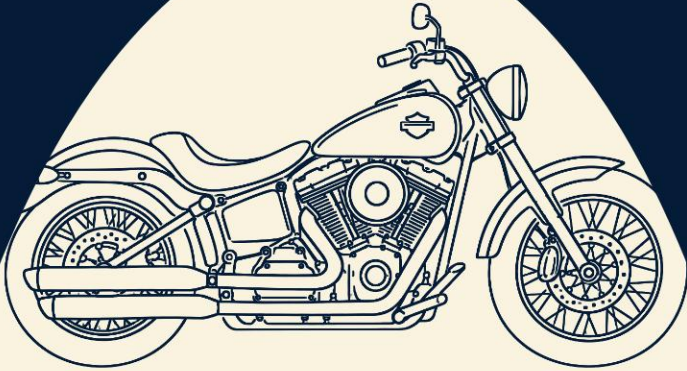
The Generation

Yé-yé took American rock, translated it, softened it, dressed it in French — and sent back an idea of French cool that Hollywood and British pop still quote.

The shout and the murmur: both still playing, sixty years on.

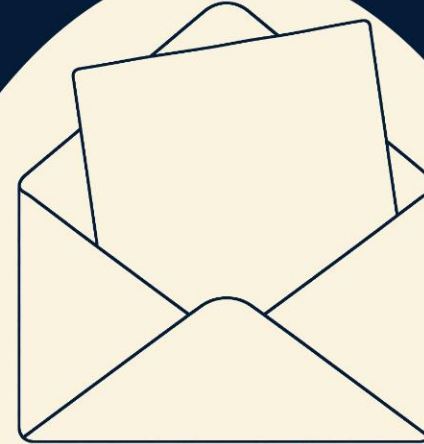
9 December 2017

A Funeral Down the Champs-Élysées



Johnny — the public monument

Seven hundred bikers lead the hearse. The President speaks on the church steps.



Françoise — the private legend

Dies 11 June 2024, aged eighty. No parade. The songs do the work.

He was the only thing three generations of French people could sing together.

Sixty Years in One Hour

Two abandoned children of the 9th arrondissement gave a generation its voice — one by shouting, one by whispering.

A radio show, a magazine and one open-air concert turned a youth into a market and a movement.

The boy who copied Elvis became the largest live performer in the history of the French language.

The girl who could not face a stage became the most quietly imitated woman in European pop.



They imported American rock. What they sent back was a French idea of cool.

Sources & Further Reading



Reading

Edgar Morin, "Salut les copains", Le Monde, 6–7 July 1963 · Françoise Hardy, Le Désespoir des singes... et autres bagatelles (memoir) · Jean-Marie Périer, Mes années 60 · Philippe Manœuvre, Johnny Hallyday.



Listening, in Order

Johnny: Souvenirs, souvenirs (1960) · Que je t'aime (1969) · Stade de France 98 (live).
Françoise: Tous les garçons et les filles (1962) · Comment te dire adieu (1968) · Message personnel (1973).



Watching

Place de la Nation, 22 June 1963 (INA archive footage) · L'Homme du train, Patrice Leconte (2002) · The Champs-Élysées homage, 9 December 2017.